Mumbai flashed in my mind. The difficulty in carrying on walking with blisters made me wonder about the difficulties that the migrant labourers and poor people of our country would have faced when they were forced to walk back to their villages during the time of the Covid-19 lockdown. The uncertainties and challenges that they faced during that time would have been incomparably harder than what I was facing. I had food, medical attention and a bed at my disposal. My pain and problems felt petty when compared to theirs.

Interestingly, one of our fellow yatris, Sachin Rao, decided to do the entire Yatra barefoot. I met him and said that I was having trouble with blisters. He smiled and told me the best way to deal with it was to walk barefoot like him. I tried it for a little while but could not do it. It was acutely discomforting. In fact, out of my concern for him, I asked him to discontinue his experiment and put on shoes. He showed me a pair of sandals in his bag and assured me that he would wear them when he felt he could no longer continue. It became a sort of a ritual for me—whenever I bumped into him, I would politely ask him to start wearing shoes and he would find ways to dodge my plea.

This ritual went on for months, and then one day during our breakfast in Ramban near Kashmir, I saw him wearing shoes for the first time; and I celebrated in front of him. This was the first time that he turned serious and said, ‘Don’t do this.’ Then he pointed to a poor old man who had somehow made his way into the camp, and said, ‘Look, he isn’t wearing any shoes either!’

‘The idea is not to give up wearing shoes, but to ensure that he gets shoes as well!’ I protested as we left for the march.

This exchange stayed with me. I kept thinking whether I had been correct in my argument. I still think I was correct, but that is not the point. While thinking about the incident, it struck me that I had not noticed the old man’s feet. I realized how desensitized I had become to poverty over time. One cannot be blamed for it either, because becoming desensitized to the hardships that ordinary Indians faced is a coping mechanism that I had developed. However, more importantly, it occurred to me that the question